Westbrook City Council

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Monday, May 4, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1189191673
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_05042026-1003

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Unofficial summary. *This is produced by Westbrook Currents, an independent site — not the City of Westbrook — and may contain mistakes. For the official record, see the City's approved minutes and the meeting video.*

Mayor’s Message & First Public Comment

Discover Downtown Westbrook Annual Update, Arbor Week Proclamation & Weekend Recap [0:34]

Discussion Summary

Discover Downtown Westbrook (DDW) Executive Director Amy Grums-Pulaski gave an extended annual update: DDW's four signature events (Winterfest, the Gala held the prior Saturday, the Vallee Square Concert Series, and Run the River), its status as one of ten Main Street America affiliates in Maine, a University of Southern Maine student mural partnership (six murals installed so far), continued support for the five Westbrook World Markets, and a “dusk to dark” paddle series with the Friends of the Presumpscot. She previewed this year's Vallee Square Concert Series (Thursdays, July 9–August 20, rain date August 28), teeing up the Resolve 2026-11 vote later in the meeting.

Mayor Morse proclaimed May 18–22, 2026 as Arbor Week, citing Westbrook's 40-plus years as a National Arbor Day Foundation “Tree City USA.” He and Councilor Chau also recapped a busy weekend: DDW's gala, a Jane's Walk (mural walk and history walk), and the second annual SEA Fest, a Southeast Asian cultural festival at Riverbank Park.

Cumberland County Commissioner Patricia “Patty” Smith (District 4) introduced herself and described county-level collaboration with Westbrook (a Habitat for Humanity housing project; a joint EMS/fire-chief training working group). Larry McWilliams then raised the City's senior property-tax-assistance program, arguing its $1,000 annual credit hasn't kept pace with rising property taxes; Mayor Morse and City Administrator Holmes supplied the program's actual figures: as of March 23, 2026, 177 people had applied and 168 had received funds, totaling $160,655 for FY26.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Unfinished Business

Order 2026-37 — Fowl & Poultry Ordinance (Rooster Ordinance) — Taken Off the Table [27:18]

Discussion Summary

Tabled since April 6, this ordinance returned with staff's May 1 revisions. The Council voted to remove it from the table, then voted to incorporate staff's amendments. Assistant City Administrator Jenny Franceschi explained the amended ordinance adds definitions for coop/pen/enclosure, reaffirms a rooster prohibition (for noise; state law covers only hens), clarifies that chickens may not range onto neighboring property, and — at Vice President Shaughnessy's request — loosens the manure-storage requirement from a “fully enclosed structure” to any “covered container.” She stressed the ordinance governs only personal-use fowl at private residences; working farms are a separate, exempt land use, and the City issues no chicken permit, acting only on complaints.

Councilor Turcotte asked about compliance timelines; Administrator Holmes and Franceschi described a voluntary-compliance-first approach, with the Animal Control Officer and police following up after a notification period.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to remove from the table passed, 6–0.

✓ Motion to amend with staff's May 1 revisions passed, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Point/Counterpoint — personal-use flock limits by lot size. The amended draft set personal-use flocks at six hens citywide, with an exception of twelve in the City's rural zoning district. From the floor, this became the evening's live debate:

> *“I'm not gonna comply to this rule unless we can increase it back to the twelve that we should have... I have seven acres of land... my neighbors don't like me anyway, so they're gonna call on anything.”*

— Resident at 383 Austin St. (heard by ASR as “Larry McQueen,” likely a mis-transcription of Larry McWilliams, a frequent commenter elsewhere in this meeting) [37:41]

Councilor Chau moved to amend the ordinance to also allow twelve hens on any residential parcel of five-or-more acres, not just the rural district — after discussion in which Vice President Shaughnessy noted the rule's real target is nuisance roosters and noise/odor, not flock size per se, the amendment was narrowed from “any acreage” to the specific five-acre threshold. A resident heard as “Fossum” (91 North St.) argued twelve was reasonable on a large lot, while an emailed public comment from Steve Egglson pressed for the ordinance to take effect immediately to curb “roosters crowing 24-7” and free-ranging flocks.

Key Decisions

✓ Amendment allowing twelve hens on residential parcels of five-plus acres passed [1:05:56] 5–1 (Councilor Turcotte opposed).

✓ Order 2026-37, as fully amended, passed its combined first-and-final reading [1:07:55] 5–1 (Turcotte opposed). Turcotte's dissent was not explained on the record beyond her earlier procedural questions

about enforcement timelines.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2026-44, -48 through -54 — Title-Only Consent Batch (Bus Purchase, Paving, Roadway & Sewer Items) [1:08:20]

Discussion Summary

Read into the record by title only, as second-and-final readings previously discussed at first reading: 2026-44 (Community Center bus purchase), 2026-48 (2026 paving bid award), 2026-49 (Route 302/East Bridge St. intersection design), 2026-50 (Saco Street roadway improvements bid), 2026-51 (sewer assessment software), 2026-52 (Public Safety Building LED lighting upgrade), 2026-53 (Lincoln Street/Mayberry Road shared-cost agreement), and 2026-54 (Saccarappa Park revitalization funding amendment).

Key Decisions

✓ All passed together by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

FY2026-2027 Budget: Second & Final Reading

[1:10:38] ***Order 2026-45 (the budget itself):*** *passed its second and final reading* ***unanimously, 6–0*** *— the same budget that passed the April 27 first reading only 5–1, now unopposed because Councilor Rairdon, the lone April dissenter, was absent tonight.*

Point/Counterpoint — public comment on the budget turned heated. Three residents spoke against the school budget in detail, citing administrative salary growth, declining school performance rankings, and rising special-education costs.

> *"13 admin salaries add up to 1.6 million dollars, that's 19% of all the salaries in the school system... since 2022, 17.4 [million]... over 40% tax increase."*

— Resident at 91 North St. (heard by ASR as both "Fossum" and "Fawson"; likely the same recurring commenter from the April 27 meeting) [1:11:59]

> *"I'm asking you guys to vote no on the school budget and the municipal budget... I believe we should be following suit on like Augusta did with their school board and they denied the school budget."*

— Mark Fournier (75 Walker St.) [1:19:59]

> *"the school department is actually adding more high-cost positions, including a new functional life skills teacher, six Ed tech threes, a speech therapist, [and] an additional occupational therapist... people have to live within our means."*

— Chuck Ellis (246 East Bridge St.) [1:27:16]

Mayor Morse responded that Westbrook remains the fourth-lowest per-pupil spender in Cumberland County and praised the School Committee's unanimous budget endorsement despite a complex year. Councilor McCambridge thanked the speakers for appearing in person rather than posting criticism online, while acknowledging rising personal costs himself, and said he'd vote yes given the district's above-average (26–27%) special-education enrollment and the value of early intervention. Councilor Turcotte then delivered the meeting's sharpest remarks, directed at online critics rather than the in-person speakers:

> *"It is the ones that never show up, never tune in, and then post things online that threaten our families and say that we are not welcome here... Shame on you. Come and tell me to my face that my family and I should be worried going outside of my house... That will be the last thing you do."*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [1:33:09]

Key Decisions

✓ Order 2026-45 (FY27 budget, second & final reading) passed unanimously, 6–0.

✓ Order 2026-46 (School budget warrants, second & final reading) passed [1:36:05] unanimously, 6–0. School Budget goes to voters at the June 9, 2026 referendum.

✓ Order 2026-47 (Wastewater budget: $6,779,069 total, incl. $4,829,623 Portland Water District assessment and $5,994,765 sewer assessment; setting 2027 sewer user rates) passed [1:37:00] unanimously, 6–0.

Resolve & New Orders (2026-11, 2026-55 through 2026-59)

Resolve 2026-11 — Vallee Square Concert Series — Mass Gathering Permit & Road Closure [1:38:50]

Found on page 174 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Approves DDW's mass gathering permit and the Vallee Square street closure for the 2026 concert series, July 9–August 20 (rain date August 28), following Amy Grums-Pulaski's earlier presentation.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-55 — TDB LLC Settlement Agreement [1:40:45]

Found on page 181 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a settlement agreement with TDB LLC, the leaseholder of city-owned land beside the parking garage (subtenant: Vertical Harvest). Mayor Morse summarized three financial benefits to the City: reimbursement of $971,000 in underground-utility relocation costs, TDB covering a significant share of the garage's operating/maintenance costs for roughly the next 90 years, and TDB guaranteeing payment of any taxes owed by its tenant. The City will separately pursue an RFP for the adjacent vacant lot.

Key Decisions

✓ **Passed by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-56 — Q3 FY26 Unappropriated Funds Report [1:43:36]

Found on page 239 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Accepts the Q3 FY26 unappropriated funds report, per standing Order 2021-121. Councilor Chau thanked recent donors to the library and police department.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-57 — Port City Architects — Public Safety Building Feasibility Study Update (First Reading) [1:44:54]

Found on page 243 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Authorizes an agreement with Port City Architects (Portland, ME), not to exceed $47,286, to update their 2022 Public Safety Building feasibility study — part of the City's broader capital planning alongside a new fire training facility and “Station 3.” Administrator Holmes clarified this update does not currently contemplate relocating dispatch to a future Station 3, given recent investment in dispatch equipment at the existing Public Safety Building, though a flexible meeting/office space there remains a possible future need.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed by unanimous roll call, 6–0 (first reading).**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-58 — Fire Department Gas Meter Replacement & Grant (First Reading) [1:49:52]

Found on page 255 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Authorizes purchase of replacement Fire Department gas meters from Bergeron Protective Clothing (Epsom, NH) for $21,512.20, partly offset by a $7,817 grant from Portland Natural Gas Transmission System; follows an earlier emergency replacement of some failed units ahead of this year's Capital Improvement Plan.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed by unanimous roll call, 6–0 (first reading).**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-59 — MaineDOT Municipal Partnership Initiative — Saco Street (First Reading) [1:52:47]

Found on page 264 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a MaineDOT Municipal Partnership Initiative agreement for Saco Street roadway improvements (Spiller Drive to William Clark Drive), with the City to be reimbursed up to $750,000 of the project's now-$1.7 million bid cost (the agreement text still cites an earlier $1.6 million estimate; Administrator Holmes noted the reimbursement cap doesn't change). Follows from Order 2026-50 (the paving bid, approved earlier tonight).

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous roll call, 6–0 (first reading).

Action Items

None.

Second Public Comment

Senior Tax Credit & Development Impact Fees [1:56:11]

Discussion Summary

Larry McWilliams returned to thank the Administration for quickly supplying the senior tax credit figures, and suggested the Council consider expanding that credit. He separately revived a 2019 proposal — previously rejected — for development impact fees, arguing the roughly 500-plus housing units currently moving through the Planning Board (where he serves as chair) should help fund the infrastructure upgrades their growth requires, citing the City's pending multi-million-dollar water system overhaul and a recently added sewer/water impact fee as a partial precedent.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Closing

Referrals, Committee Reports & Adjournment [1:59:09]

Discussion Summary

No referrals, no committee report updates, and no executive session. Meeting adjourned by unanimous roll call.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to adjourn passed, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was transcribed with AI-assisted speech-to-text and speaker identification. This process cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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